I remember discussing it with Anjali and Ajit. We were sitting in the first-floor lounge of my house when I told them that I was thinking about retiring after the West Indies series. The second Test would be my 200th and I would not have another opportunity to retire on home soil till the end of 2014 and I wasn't sure if I could battle with injuries for that long. There was no point in dragging things out if my heart wasn't in it.

Anjali and Ajit were both fully supportive and Anjali said that she was behind me in anything that I decided. She just wanted me to be sure that I wouldn't regret the decision a few months down the line. Ajit agreed that the timing was right and that it was a good decision to retire in India. Playing my final Test away from home just wouldn't be the same.

Once I had made up my mind, I decided to ask the BCCI if they would consider allotting the second Test to Mumbai. It would mean that I would play my last series in front of my home crowd and above all I would get my mother to watch me for the first time in my life. My mother had never watched me play live and this was something I really wanted to do for her. I had begun my first-class career in Mumbai in 1987 and playing my last Test at the Wankhede would mean I had completed the circle. It was as if I was being told from above that this was an opportunity to thank cricket. There would be no better occasion to pay my respects to the game than in a farewell Test match in Mumbai.

When I talked through the decision with my friend and manager Vinod Naidu and our close friend Aparna Santhanam, it turned out to be a memorable and magical evening. I opened a bottle of champagne and we toasted the game of cricket and all the years gone by. There was no sense of gloom or dejection or talk of anything ending. Instead, there was a sense of joy, of anticipation and fulfilment. We laughed and reminisced about twenty-four years on the cricket field and chatted happily about the upcoming series. It all convinced me that I had taken the right decision. The timing was perfect. It was a call made from the heart. I wasn't prepared to let my mind interfere in the decision because the mind has a habit of asking too many awkward questions. I had not given a thought to what I would do after retirement. I was simply sure that this was the best time to stop.

It was a day later, on the morning of 10 October 2013, that I called BCCI President N Srinivasan to communicate my decision to retire. He said that while the BCCI would always want me to continue for as long as I wanted, they would also back me on any decision. He was clear that